

The Executor's Checklist

for coin, currency, jewelry, and collectible collections in an estate

A collection is often the least documented asset in an estate and the easiest one to lose value on. The steps below protect the estate, the family, and you as its fiduciary, in the order they should happen.

First 48 hours: secure and document

- Secure the collection where it sits. Do not move it, divide it, or let family members take pieces before it is documented.
- Photograph everything in place: wide shots of each container, then closer shots of trays and albums. Date the photos.
- Do not clean anything. Cleaning a coin can reduce its value by half or more. Handle coins by the edges only.
- Gather every paper that travels with the collection: purchase receipts, prior appraisals, grading certificates, insurance riders, and any inventory the owner kept.

Before any sale conversation

- Confirm the estate's insurance covers the collection where it is stored. Many homeowner policies cap collectibles at a few thousand dollars.
- Obtain a written valuation before entertaining any offer. A number on paper, prepared for the estate file, is the only defense against selling blind.
- Treat any immediate cash offer as one buyer's opening position, not the market. The first offer on an undocumented collection is almost never the best one.
- Do not ship anything of significance. Items of real value should move by insured, documented transport or not at all.

Realizing value for the estate

- Compare the two paths: a direct sale (one buyer, one number, immediate) versus consignment to auction (competing bidders, documented results, settlement after sale).
 - If consigning, require in writing: the fee, the reserve, the settlement timeline, insurance while in the consignee's custody, and a chain-of-custody record for every item.
 - Ask whether any written offer the estate already holds can be set as the auction reserve, so the estate is protected at that figure and can only do better.
 - Keep the valuation, the agreement, and the final settlement accounting together in the estate file. They are your record of prudent administration.
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Our office prepares written valuations for estate files within five business days and handles consignment from insured pickup through a single settlement wire. Consultations are private, by appointment, and without obligation.

The Park Cities Gallery

Coins, Jewelry & Collectibles

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Prepared as a courtesy for executors, attorneys, and trustees. This checklist is general information, not legal advice. Valuations referenced are written valuations prepared for estate documentation purposes.